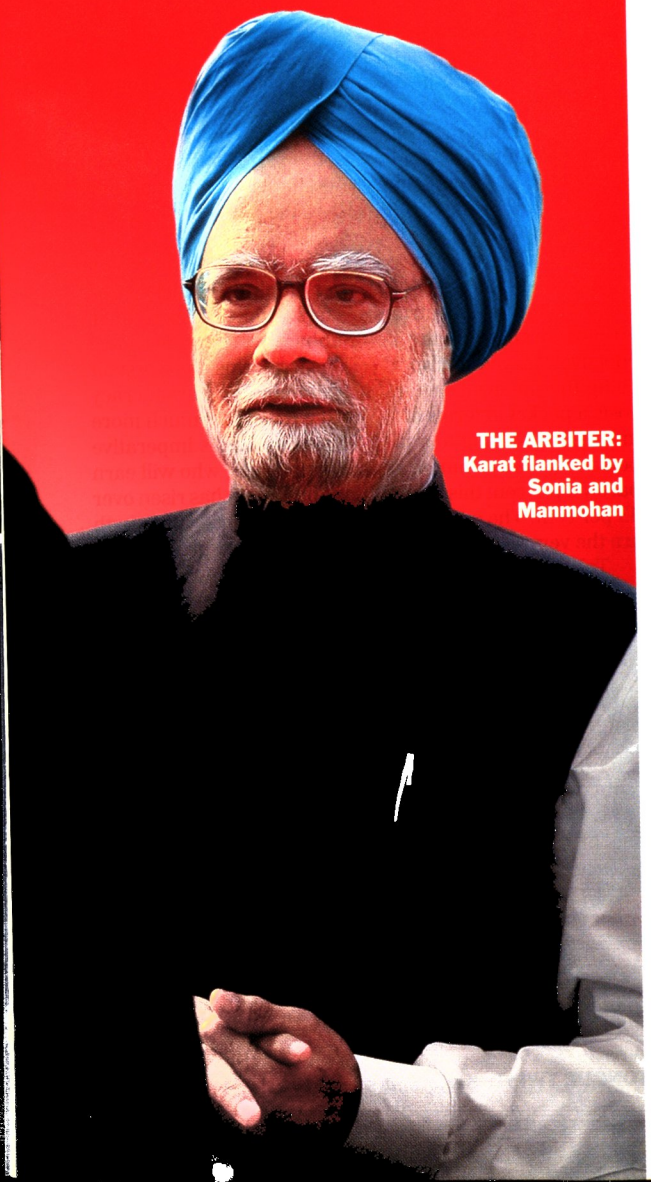


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He plans well and moves deliberately, speaks softly and acts tough. He's kept the UPA Government and the Congress leadership on a tight leash. Inside the mind of the Indian Left's Big Brother.



THE ARBITER:
Karat flanked by
Sonia and
Manmohan

■ By Satarupa Bhattacharjya with Prabhu Chawla

The first tryst with power begins with a deception in appearance. You realise it the moment you are initiated into the sanctum sanctorum of Prakash Karat, a bespectacled calmness, his greyness in perfect harmony with the walls, characteristically communist in their dull monotony. By non-Marxist standards, the room in AKG Bhavan, the CPI(M) headquarters in the Capital, is too small to be the office of India's second most powerful politician—and the first in the House of Red. The dictator of the Indian proletariat may not require a bunker larger or more luxurious than this. As he settles down behind an uncluttered table, Lenin and the great dead of Indian communism, Sundarayya and EMS, stare down from their framed sepia grandeur in approval. His words are soft, and if you are looking for a soundbite, he won't oblige. They have, however, the resonance of a politician with conviction, no matter that conviction is born out of an ideological fundamentalism that continues to influence the trajectory of 21st-century India. Words that can kill a deal, control the freedom of the market and send intimations of political mortality to South Block and 10 Janpath.

He plays the conscience keeper of the UPA Government without being a part of it. He doesn't have to be officially in power to change the course of governance. He alone has the freedom to oppose and support at the same time. When Prime Minister Manmohan Singh wants to be the strategic friend of Washington, Karat becomes the most vociferous votary of national interest. A nuclear pact with America, he tells the Government that can't survive without the Left's support, is a Faustian deal. And he wants Marx to manage the malls. The Big Brother of the Indian Left has dominated the agenda of India 2007; the consistency of his dogma triumphed over the fragile conviction of the prime minister. India is still swayed by the kinetic force of the Karat doctrine. As *The New York Times* wrote, "Karat and his party have lately emerged as a sharp and dangerous weapon against the coalition Government, making it plain that though the communists do not have the strength to rule India, they have the power to spoil the plans of those who do." From Delhi to New York, the K word has cast its spell.

It was the nuclear deal that brought out the terminator in the comrade, who speaks soft and acts tough. It was a deal through which the prime minister sought his place in history. The deal defined two idealists who had never contested an election, though one of them didn't have the political courage to stand by his conviction. For Karat, the UPA Government's first betrayal was when it voted along with the US on the Iran nuclear issue. The Marxists were further provoked by the joint military exercises with the US at the Kalaikunda airbase in West Bengal. And there was no mention of the strategic relations with the US in the common minimum programme. "The UPA Government has not set out a strategic policy document. Nor is the foreign policy perspective clearly spelt out. What stands out is the step-by-step movement towards a strategic engagement with the US, in which the latter's interests predominate and this shift is camouflaged with evasive and high-sounding pronouncements. The Manmohan Singh Government has failed to give